

IN THE HIGH COURT FOR THE STATE OF TELANGANA

Om Menon vs The State Of West Bengal ... on 25 June, 2023
(2024) 5 SCC 423, 2023 SCC OnLine SC 321
Bench: Vipul M. Pancholi, J. and Prathiba M. Singh, J.

JUDGMENT

Vipul M. Pancholi, J.

1. The applicant, Om Menon, has approached this Court under Section 482 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023, seeking regular bail in connection with C.R. No. 86 of 2024 registered with Special Enquiry Cell, West Bengal. The offences alleged are punishable under Section 111 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023 and Section 66D of the Information Technology Act, 2000.
2. The prosecution case is that a coordinated digital fraud syndicate caused wrongful loss of Rs. 0.9 Crores between 18-11-2022 and 03-02-2023. The applicant was arrested on 08-10-2022 for allegedly providing logistics and server infrastructure to the prime conspirators.
3. Mr. Dave, learned Senior Counsel for the applicant, submitted that the investigation is complete and the charge sheet was filed on 06-08-2021. He contends the applicant had no mens rea, and that the CDR and cell-site records relied upon by the prosecution were seized without mandatory certification under Section 63 of the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhinyam (BSA), 2023.
4. Counsel placed reliance on (2014) 8 SCC 273 in the case of Arnesh Kumar v. State of Bihar, and on (2022) 10 SCC 51 in the case of Satender Kumar Antil v. CBI, on the principle that continued custody must not become punitive where trial will take time.
5. Learned APP Ms. Khan opposed, contending that bank ledger audits and the panchanama dated 23-11-2023 establish the applicant's proximity to the operating nodes, and that Ex. P-14 seizure memo links the leased servers to the applicant.

6. Upon consideration of the charge sheet, this Court finds custodial interrogation has concluded; no direct fund trail touches the applicant's accounts; and trial will take considerable time. Further detention would serve no purpose.

7. The applicant is directed to be released on bail on executing a P.R. Bond of Rs. 50,000/- with one or two local sureties. Bail application is allowed.

Prathiba M. Singh, J. - I agree.